

» TOURNAMENT WRAP
ULTIMATE TABLE TENNIS



Perfect defence: U Mumba became the second team to retain its title in Ultimate Table Tennis after beating Goa Challengers in the final. UTT

Sustainability over spectacle

With more franchises nearing break-even and a new generation of Indian stars emerging, the league's **long-term vision** is beginning to pay off.

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A 1,170-strong crowd thronged the Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Indoor Stadium in Panjim, Goa, as it witnessed U Mumba become the second team to retain its UTT title. The Manush Shah-led franchise beat home side Goa Challengers 8-5 to bring the curtains down on the seventh edition.

However, for much of the edition, the venue looked largely empty, with only the occasional bursts of *dhols* and chants filling the air. There were rumours that Kolkata and Goa were bringing in children to fill some of the seats, and those two were perhaps the only franchises investing in the *dhols*.

Attracting audiences to the venue organically has been an issue for UTT since its

inception. But Vita Dani, Co-Promoter of UTT, feels that gate receipts don't add much to the league's balance sheet.

"What matters is good sponsors, and I am very proud to say that we now have some credible partners for the league. Look at Butterfly, which is a global brand in multiple countries, and the newest rage, ChatGPT. The fact that they have come on board itself is very encouraging for me," she said.

Butterfly came on board as UTT's title sponsor ahead of this season, signing a five-year deal to support the Indian table tennis ecosystem while also providing equipment. Butterfly president Takako Osawa revealed that the company isn't expecting immediate returns but is happy to be "engaged with what's happening in the Indian table tennis community".